

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Human Resources English

Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For HR business partners, recruiters, talent managers, people managers, employee-relations staff, learning teams, compensation analysts, and HR-adjacent leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Onboarding and Role Clarity

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

03 Performance Feedback and Documentation

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

04 Employee Relations and Investigations

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

06 Policy Communication and Compliance

Clarify missing information before responding.

07 Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

08 Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | Speak and respond

Give two minutes of preparation. Run the partner exchange, switch roles, and add the follow-up challenge. Observe whether the listener can act on the message.

35-47 minutes | Write for a real reader

Learners write the short message using only case facts. Partners check clarity, certainty, and the requested next step.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, shorten the first conversation and assign writing for follow-up. For 90 minutes, add 15 minutes for a second case and 15 minutes for the final challenge. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A hiring manager asks for a candidate with "good cultural fit." The role requirements do not explain which behaviors matter.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: job requirement, structured interview, bias, candidate experience.

Model response

Which job-related behaviors do you mean? Let's use clear requirements and consistent interview questions so candidates are assessed against the work the role actually involves.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: what this means.

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. C - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: the review starts.
2. B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Onboarding and Role Clarity

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A new starter has accounts and equipment but no first-month priorities. Their manager assumes the onboarding checklist covers expectations.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: role clarity, onboarding, manager check-in, success measure.

Model response

Could we agree on three first-month priorities and a check-in date? The checklist covers setup; the new starter also needs to know what successful work looks like.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Performance Feedback and Documentation

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

CASE

An employee's last two reports omitted the agreed summary section. The manager wants to discuss the issue without making a judgment about motivation.

Teach this move

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Vocabulary to check: performance gap, documentation, expectation, support plan.

Model response

The last two reports did not include the summary section we agreed on. That made review slower. What would help you include it consistently, and can we check the next report together?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Second-round challenge

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Language-check answers

1. A - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date. The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.
2. C - What is making this part of the task difficult? An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Employee Relations and Investigations

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An employee raises a concern about a colleague. The receiving manager has only one account and is preparing an intake note.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: employee relations, harassment, retaliation, confidentiality.

Model response

I'll record the concern in the employee's own terms and distinguish reported information from established findings. The appropriate process should determine the next steps; we should not prejudge the outcome.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

An employee sees a published pay range and assumes everyone in the role receives the midpoint. The HR team has the relevant compensation policy.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: pay band, job level, equity review, benefits.

Model response

The range describes the span for the role, not a promise of the midpoint. Let's review the applicable policy and the factors the organization uses to explain an individual's position within the range.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. A - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Policy Communication and Compliance

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A manager asks whether a requested work adjustment is automatically approved. HR has not yet reviewed the request under the applicable process.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: policy, accommodation, precedent, compliance.

Model response

Could you describe the requested adjustment and the work requirement involved? We'll review it through the appropriate process. I cannot confirm an outcome before that review.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: what this means.

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: the review starts.
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

Two colleagues disagree about who owns a recurring task. Both say the other failed to help, but the responsibilities were never documented.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: mediation, behavioral example, operating agreement, accountability.

Model response

Let's identify the task, the handoff point, and what each person understood. Then we can agree on responsibilities and a check-in instead of continuing with assumptions about intent.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. C - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. B - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A restructuring message uses the phrase "small changes" even though some positions may be affected. The final details are not yet confirmed.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: restructuring, position elimination, severance, talking points.

Model response

The wording may understate the possible impact. Let's say clearly what is confirmed, what remains undecided, and where employees can ask questions, using the approved communication process.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. B - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. A - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.